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**Research Design:  
Qualitative, Quantitative,  
and Mixed Methods  
Approaches, by John  
Creswell and J. David  
Creswell. Thousand Oaks,  
CA: Sage Publication, Inc.  
275 pages, \$67.00  
(Paperback).**

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### **Overview of book**

For a quarter of a century, John Creswell's *Research Design: Qualitative, Quantitative, and Mixed Methods Approaches* had been a leader in the field of social science research methods. Now in its slightly expanded fifth edition, Creswell has added his son, J. David Creswell, to the project. Creswell senior, a specialist in both qualitative and mixed methods research, utilizes the quantitative expertise of his son for this latest edition. As a result, this edition introduces quantitative examples that are applicable for both novice and seasoned researchers.

Like the previous edition, the book contains 10 chapters intended to aid the development of a plan or proposal for a research study. The chapters are divided into two sections. Section one includes considerations for the reader prior to designing a study. Section two explores the three broad approaches of inquiry in more detail. Chapter one gives considerations for the selection of a research approach and helps guide the researcher to an approach that aligns with their worldview and epistemological foundation. The chapter reinforces general ideas on epistemological foundations. For instance, Bryman (2012) articulates the importance of aligning one's research approach and epistemological position. The topic of chapter two is how to conduct an extensive literature review germane to the research topic. The authors effectively demonstrate how the literature is instrumental in the development of the research project. Chapter three explores how theory is used differently in quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods designs and discusses the use of theory as a guiding framework for the research study. The last chapter in section one, chapter four, discusses strategies for writing a rigorous

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study and ethical considerations. Overall, the ideas discussed in section one are central to a research study and provide a roadmap for the exploration of research.

Section two, Designing Research, consists of chapters 5-10. This section explores the quantitative, qualitative and mixed methods studies in further depth. Chapter five discusses the critical features of setting up a research study. This consists of framing a research problem within the context of the literature. Chapter six is solely dedicated to articulating a clear, concise and effective *research purpose* which is appropriate, given its importance in the success of a research study. After establishing the intent of a study through the research purpose statement, the authors discuss how the development of research questions and or hypotheses guide the study (chapter seven). The authors stress the many different types of research questions and hypotheses that can be formulated through a variety of research designs. By providing basic scripts for writing research questions and hypotheses, the text is a resourceful tool, for beginners and experts alike, in the development of proposals and papers. For the final chapters of the book, the authors focus on specific epistemological, ontological, and methodological considerations of quantitative research (chapter eight), qualitative research (chapter nine), and mixed-methods research (chapter 10).

## Updates

One of most significant contributions of the fifth edition is the expansion of discussion on quantitative approaches. Chapter three of the book receives the greatest upgrade with the introduction of *causality* and the idea that quantitative research is concerned with evaluating causal claims. The authors dedicate more space in the book to helping researchers understand concepts such as variables (independent, dependent, predictor, outcome, intervening/mediating, and or moderating). The book's discussion on power analysis is also a prime example of the many quantitative sections that received some degree of updating from the previous edition, with the expansion of newer examples and terminology. The discussion on the use of software was also updated to include the expansion of newer technologies and the exploration of different data, such as visual images or social media materials.

There are more than 30 new references added to the fifth edition, with updates to the in-text citations. Much of the rest of the fifth edition and its 275 pages reads verbatim to the fourth edition (273 pages). The book's design also received an upgrade. Aesthetically, the green cover and notes of the fifth edition are favorable to the black cover and blue notations included in the fourth edition. The font sizing, headings, and overall design of the fifth edition makes it more aesthetically pleasing.

## Features

Perhaps one of the most important aspects of the book is the companion website and resources. The helpfulness of the additional resources provides an in-depth guide to exploring research and is a unique extension of the text. A quiz and at least one sample article is included for every chapter. Most chapters also have a video or several, some presented by Creswell himself. The videos come complete with a downloadable transcript. Additionally, the companion website provides resources that enable users to save or share the clips, embed the clips on other websites, and cite the clips in APA, Harvard, Chicago, or MLA formatting. Discussions on the introduction (chapter five) and the purpose statement (chapter six) unfortunately do not have videos. All of the videos are mobile friendly for iOS devices.

Every chapter of the book is accompanied by a mobile-friendly quiz. The quizzes are a great compliment to the text, as they encourage the reader to re-engage with the material and recall or revise one's knowledge-base. Although the quizzes are a great self-assessment tool that engage the researcher, it would be helpful to receive an explanation of why answers are considered right or wrong.

Free and unrestricted access to Sage Journals publication relating to all 10 chapters is sure to be a distinctive and favorable aspect of the companion website. Much like the videos, the journal articles can be easily shared, cited, or downloaded. To access related articles, one will need some level of access to the Sage database.

The research proposal sample and templates are invaluable features that demonstrate the authors' concern for this edition to be a learning experience and resource for the reader. Additionally, through a free login portal, the instructor can access several features that can guide their class preparation. For instance, the sample syllabus

bi and unit PowerPoint slides can easily be downloaded and edited to meet the needs of instructors, students and courses. The website also contains comprehensive lecture notes for the instructor.

## Overall recommendation

The fifth iteration of *Research Design: Qualitative, Quantitative, and Mixed Methods Approaches* is an exemplary resource guide for anyone designing a research study. Readers are provided a map that is easy to follow and the text is written to be comprehended regardless of one's vernacular. From the onset of the research exploration process, this book will aid with conceptualizing what you want to study, why or how you want to study it, and provide the tools needed to tackle the project. The book includes expanded discussions relative to the quantitative approach such as power analysis that is worth exploring. The companion website provides a number of great resources that supports both researchers and instructors. The easily accessible content of the companion site on iOS devices will allow for an independent exploration consistent with modern expectations. Although the online access included with the fifth edition adds value to the new addition, the actual text of the fourth edition is near identical to that of the fifth. Thus, although the book is certainly recommended to newcomers, those who own previous editions are unlikely to find the purchase of the newest edition to be worth their while. However, the book is a must have for those designing research, particularly novices.

## References

- Bryman, A. (2012). *Social research methods*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Creswell, J. W., & Creswell, J. D. (2018). *Research Design: Qualitative, Quantitative, and Mixed Methods Approaches*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publication, Inc.